

Free Arthritis Exercise Classes Near You in England

Practical NHS-backed advice on free arthritis exercise classes near me england.

By **Living With Arthritis UK** · Reviewed by **Louis Maxwell** (HCPC Registered Physiotherapist) · 2026-07-24 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Free Arthritis Exercise Classes Near You in England

Quick Answer: Free arthritis exercise classes in England are available through Exercise on Referral (ask your GP), leisure centre Active Health schemes, Versus Arthritis community programmes, and Age UK. Many NHS Trusts fund free exercise specifically for people with long-term conditions including arthritis.

Regular exercise is one of the most effective treatments for arthritis, recommended by NICE as a core management strategy. Free or subsidised exercise classes are available across England — here's how to find them.

Exercise on Referral (GP Referral Schemes)

Most GP practices can refer patients with arthritis to subsidised or free exercise programmes at local leisure centres. Ask your GP specifically about Exercise on Referral or Physical Activity Referral schemes in your area. These provide a 12–16 week supervised programme designed for people with long-term conditions.

What Exercise on Referral Includes

- Initial assessment by a qualified exercise professional
- Tailored exercise plan for your condition
- Supervised sessions at a leisure centre or gym
- Progress reviews and ongoing support

- Often includes hydrotherapy or pool access
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Leisure Centre Active Health Programmes



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Many local authority leisure centres run Active Health or Let's Get Active programmes free or at reduced cost for people with medical conditions. Contact your local leisure centre and ask specifically about arthritis classes.

Versus Arthritis and Charity Classes

Versus Arthritis supports free exercise classes including Tai Chi, gentle yoga, hydrotherapy, and chair-based exercise across England. Use their service finder at versusarthritis.org or call 0800 5200 520. Age UK also runs free exercise groups for older people with arthritis across

England.

Q&A;



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Question: Do I need a diagnosis to join free exercise classes? **Short answer:** For GP referral schemes, yes. For community classes run by charities, most welcome anyone with joint pain even without a formal diagnosis.

Question: What if I'm housebound? **Short answer:** Free home-based exercise resources are available online via Versus Arthritis's YouTube channel and the NHS Fitness Studio. Community physiotherapy home visits are also available in some areas.

Question: Are hydrotherapy classes available free? **Short answer:** Hydrotherapy through the NHS is free but typically requires a physiotherapy referral. Some leisure centres offer free pool sessions for people on Exercise on Referral schemes.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk